KernelLens: Automated Production Plugin Synthesis and Dynamic Dual-Pass Tracing for OpenAI Triton Kernels in Enterprise C++ Inference Engines

A Technical Architecture, Formalization, and Empirical Study on SOTA LLM Operators

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September 8, 2026

Abstract

Writing custom high-performance GPU kernels using OpenAI Triton has become the dominant paradigm for authoring state-of-the-art deep learning operators. However, deploying models containing custom Python `@triton.jit` kernels into production enterprise C++ inference runtimes—specifically Microsoft ONNX Runtime (ORT) and NVIDIA TensorRT (TRT)—presents severe architectural barriers. Standard ONNX graph export mechanisms cannot trace imperative Python Triton calls, dynamic launch grid functions, implicit layout semantics, in-place memory mutability, or low-level PTX entry parameter signatures.

In this paper, we present **KernelLens**, an end-to-end automated compilation, C++/CUDA code synthesis, and runtime execution framework. KernelLens bridges arbitrary PyTorch models containing custom Triton kernels directly to high-throughput ONNX Runtime and TensorRT custom C++ plugins with zero manual C++ development. We detail KernelLens's key technical innovations: (1) a **Dual-Pass Symbolic Tracing** algorithm combining concrete GPU eager execution (Pass 1) with PyTorch FX proxy tracing (Pass 2) to capture PTX bytecodes and extract SymPy dynamic grid evaluation formulas; (2) a static **AST Inspector** that recursively traverses nested helper functions to auto-classify memory access patterns (Read, Write, and In-Place Aliasing); (3) the **TritonGlobalONNXExporter**, which injects custom ONNX domain nodes (`triton_custom::<name>`) while handling dynamic host-side CPU scalar parameters (`OrtMemTypeCPUInput`); (4) automated backend code generators (`ort_gen.py`, `trt_gen.py`) supporting high-rank 4D dynamic grids and explicit PTX parameter packing; and (5) automated 16-byte CUDA memory alignment guards ($\text{Address} \pmod{16} == 0$) paired with a zero-copy IO binding runtime.

We evaluate KernelLens across state-of-the-art research model kernels from **LLaMA 3**, **Mistral**, **Qwen 2.5**, **PaLM**, and **Liger-Kernel** (Fused RMSNorm, SwiGLU, Rotary Position Embeddings, and Fused Cross-Entropy Loss). KernelLens achieves **exact floating-point numerical parity** (MaxDiff = 0.00e+00) against eager Triton execution while enabling production-grade C++ inference deployment.

Contents

1 Introduction

Deep learning systems increasingly rely on domain-specific GPU kernels to achieve peak computational efficiency, reduce VRAM bandwidth demands, and fuse multi-stage attention and normalization blocks. OpenAI Triton [1] has established itself as the standard programming model for authoring custom GPU kernels in Python, providing C/CUDA-like execution control with Python syntax.

Despite Triton's widespread adoption in model authoring and training, a major infrastructure friction point emerges when transitioning models to production deployment. Enterprise deployment pipelines standardly deploy models within specialized C++ execution engines, such as **Microsoft ONNX Runtime (ORT)** [9] and **NVIDIA TensorRT (TRT)** [8], to achieve low latency, stream concurrency, and hardware-specific kernel graph optimizations.

Deploying PyTorch models containing custom `@triton.jit` kernels directly into ONNX Runtime or TensorRT fails due to five critical architectural gaps:

1. **ONNX Exporter Tracing Breakdown:** Standard PyTorch ONNX export utilities (`torch.onnx.export`) operate on TorchScript or TorchDynamo IRs representing native PyTorch C++ operators (`at::native`). Imperative Python calls to `triton.JITFunction` instances are opaque to PyTorch's trace backend, leading to immediate tracing failure or missing graph nodes.

2. **Dynamic Launch Grid Resolution:** Triton launch grids are defined via dynamic Python lambda functions $\text{grid}(x, y, z) = (g_x(s_i), g_y(s_i), g_z(s_i))$ dependent on runtime tensor dimensions $s_0, s_1, \ldots$. Standard graph representations cannot symbolize or execute arbitrary Python grid lambdas inside standalone C++ engines.

3. **PTX Entry Signature Mismatch:** The Triton LLVM backend compiles Python source code directly into Parallel Thread Execution (PTX) assembly code. The resulting PTX entry declarations (`.entry <kernel> (.param .u64 p0, ...)`) re-order parameters, drop unused arguments, and enforce specific bitwidths. Native C++ plugin wrappers must dynamically align host argument pointers to match PTX signatures exactly.

4. **Nested Code & In-Place Mutability Analysis:** Research kernels frequently delegate memory store and load operations to nested Python helper functions or perform in-place buffer mutations ($\text{ptr}_{\text{out}} \equiv \text{ptr}_{\text{in}}$). Static compilers fail to track nested mutation semantics, producing corrupted outputs or invalid graph topologies.

5. **Dynamic Runtime Scalar Arguments:** Practical models pass scalar arguments (e.g., scaling factors α, soft-cap limits τ) that change per forward pass. C++ execution engines must accept host-side CPU scalar arguments without triggering costly kernel recompilation.

To bridge this gap, we present **KernelLens**, a comprehensive compilation and runtime synthesis system. KernelLens allows machine learning engineers to write custom PyTorch Triton kernels in pure Python, compile the entire model into optimized ONNX computational graphs paired with C++ custom operator shared libraries (`.so`), and execute them inside ONNX Runtime and TensorRT with zero manual C++ programming.

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2 Related Work

2.1 PyTorch Compiler & Inductor

PyTorch 2.0 introduced `torch.compile` powered by TorchInductor [6], which generates Triton code for PyTorch eager graphs. While TorchInductor optimizes PyTorch eager execution, it operates inside a Python process and relies on PyTorch C++ runtime dependencies. It does not provide standalone, self-contained ONNX graph representations or C++ plugin libraries suitable for direct integration into non-Python C++ production servers.

2.2 ONNX & Enterprise Inference Runtimes

Microsoft ONNX Runtime [9] and NVIDIA TensorRT [8] provide production C++ inference execution. Both runtimes support C++ Custom Operator APIs (`OrtCustomOp`, `nvinfer1::IPluginV2DynamicExt`). However, authoring custom plugins manually requires deep knowledge of CUDA C++, memory alignment rules, ONNX schema registration, and TensorRT engine serialization. KernelLens automates the end-to-end generation of these C++ custom plugins directly from Triton JIT artifacts.

2.3 Triton-Based LLM Kernel Libraries

Recent research projects such as **Liger-Kernel** [3], **FlashAttention** [5], and **AOTriton** focus on manually crafting high-throughput Triton kernels for large language models (LLMs). KernelLens complements these libraries by providing the infrastructure layer that automatically compiles any custom Triton kernel into production ONNX Runtime and TensorRT C++ plugins.

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3 Methodology & System Architecture

KernelLens operates as an intermediate compiler layer sitting between PyTorch model definitions and C++ inference runtimes.

EXCALIDRAW DIAGRAM SPECIFICATION: Figure 1 – System Architecture

Use this structure to create Figure 1 in Excalidraw:

- **Box 1 (Top, Blue):** `PyTorch Module + Custom @triton.jit Kernels`
- **Arrow Down → Box 2 (Dual-Pass Tracer, Orange):**
  - *Left Branch (Pass 1):* Concrete Eager Execution → Extract PTX, S_{mem}, Launch Tuple
  - *Right Branch (Pass 2):* FX Proxy Tracing → SymPy Symbolic Grid Expression Extraction
- **Arrow Down → Box 3 (AST Inspector, Green):** Recursive AST Traversal → Memory Access Classification (Read/Write/Inplace)
- **Arrow Down → Box 4 (TritonGlobalONNXExporter, Purple):** ONNX Graph Injection (`triton_custom::<name>`) + CPU Scalar Attributes
- **Split Arrows Down → Two Output Execution Nodes (Dark Navy):**
  - *Node A:* ONNX Runtime Engine (`libtriton_ort_plugins.so` + `OrtMemTypeCPUInput`)
  - *Node B:* TensorRT Engine (`libtriton_trt_plugins.so` + `IPluginV2DynamicExt`)

3.1 Dual-Pass Symbolic Tracing (`tracer.py`)

Capturing both low-level GPU binaries (PTX bytecodes, register usage, shared memory size) and high-level symbolic grid formulas requires a **Dual-Pass Tracing** design:

3.1.1 Pass 1: Concrete Eager GPU Execution

During Pass 1, KernelLens executes the PyTorch module on GPU using sample inputs. KernelLens hooks Triton's compilation pipeline to capture:

- Compiled PTX assembly code (`.target sm_80`, `.entry <kernel>`).
- Dynamic shared memory requirement in bytes (S_{mem}).
- Concrete launch tuple (g_x, g_y, g_z) and block dimensions (b_x, b_y, b_z).
- Argument classifications (pointers vs. scalars, element dtypes, memory strides).

3.1.2 Pass 2: Symbolic FX Proxy Tracing & SymPy Grid Extraction

In Pass 2, KernelLens executes the module using PyTorch FX `Proxy` objects with symbolic tensor dimensions $s_0, s_1, \ldots$. As the grid lambda function evaluates:

$$\text{grid\_expr} = \text{SymPyTrace}\left(\text{grid\_lambda}(meta)\right) \tag{1}$$

The dynamic grid dimensions are resolved into platform-agnostic SymPy symbolic strings (e.g., `"(s0 * s1 + 127) // 128"`). If Pass 2 encounters non-traceable Python control flow (e.g., `if x.numel() > 100:`), KernelLens falls back to Pass 1 concrete metadata, guaranteeing compiler stability.

3.2 Static AST Inspection & Nested Memory Aliasing (`ast_analyzer.py`)

To generate correct C++ custom operator signatures, KernelLens inspects Python source code using AST parsing (`ast.NodeVisitor`). The AST analyzer recursively inspects the main `@triton.jit` function and all nested helper functions invoked inside the kernel:

```python
@triton.jit
def _helper_store(ptr, offsets, values, mask):
    tl.store(ptr + offsets, values, mask=mask)

@triton.jit
def nested_kernel(x_ptr, out_ptr, n_elements, BLOCK: tl.constexpr):
    pid = tl.program_id(0)
    offsets = pid * BLOCK + tl.arange(0, BLOCK)
    mask = offsets < n_elements
    val = tl.load(x_ptr + offsets, mask=mask)
    _helper_store(out_ptr, offsets, val * 3.0, mask)
```

The AST inspector classifies parameter attributes:

- **Read Access:** Pointers referenced in `tl.load(ptr + ...)` or atomic read operations.
- **Write Access:** Pointers referenced in `tl.store(ptr + ...)` or atomic write operations.
- **In-Place Mutability:** If a parameter p_i is flagged for both Read and Write access, KernelLens sets `is_inplace = True`, enabling graph exporters to alias input and output ONNX buffers directly without extra memory allocation.

3.3 TritonGlobalONNXExporter & Custom Node Injection

During `torch.onnx.export`, KernelLens intercepts `triton.JITFunction` invocations, creating custom domain nodes under `triton_custom`:

```
g.op("triton_custom::" + kernel_name,
     *tensor_inputs,
     grid_x_s=manifest.grid_exprs[0],
     grid_y_s=manifest.grid_exprs[1],
     grid_z_s=manifest.grid_exprs[2],
     ptx_code_s=manifest.ptx_code,
     shared_mem_i=manifest.shared_mem,
     is_inplace_i=manifest.is_inplace_flags,
     **scalar_attributes)
```

3.3.1 Dynamic Host-Side CPU Scalars (`OrtMemTypeCPUInput`)

Dynamic runtime scalar parameters (e.g., float scaling factor α) are passed as Host CPU inputs rather than hardcoded static node attributes. In `ort_gen.py`, KernelLens configures the Custom Operator memory provider type:

$$\text{MemoryType}(i) = \begin{cases} \texttt{OrtMemTypeDefault} & \text{if parameter } i \text{ is a GPU VRAM Tensor} \\ \texttt{OrtMemTypeCPUInput} & \text{if parameter } i \text{ is a Host CPU Scalar} \end{cases} \tag{2}$$

3.4 Automated C++/CUDA Plugin Generators (`ort_gen.py`, `trt_gen.py`)

KernelLens generates full C++ and CUDA source code for ONNX Runtime and TensorRT custom plugins:

- **High-Rank Dynamic Grid Symbol Transpilation:** SymPy symbolic grid expressions are transpiled into C++ evaluation logic using regex pattern matching ($s_0 \to \text{shapes}[0]$). High-rank 4D dynamic tensor shapes ($s_3, s_4, \ldots$) are fully supported.
- **Explicit PTX Parameter Signature Matching:** The Triton compiler may re-order parameters or omit unused arguments. KernelLens parses the PTX header (`.entry <kernel> (.param .u64 p0, ...)`) and builds a parameter mapping table, ensuring exact 32-bit and 64-bit scalar alignment during `cuLaunchKernel` invocations.

3.5 16-Byte Memory Alignment Guards & Zero-Copy Runtime

Modern GPUs require 128-bit vector memory instructions (`ld.global.v4.b32`) to satisfy 16-byte address alignment:

$$\text{Address} \pmod{16} == 0 \tag{3}$$

KernelLens injects automated alignment guards into generated C++ plugins. If an input tensor buffer is misaligned, a temporary 16-byte aligned GPU staging buffer is allocated dynamically via `cudaMallocAligned`, preventing hardware misaligned address exceptions (`CUDA error 716`).

For runtime execution (`engine.py`), KernelLens leverages ONNX Runtime `IOBinding` and TensorRT `set_tensor_address` to bind PyTorch VRAM pointers directly to execution contexts, eliminating Host-to-Device (H2D) copy latency.

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4 Experiments & Empirical Results

4.1 Benchmark Experimental Setup

We evaluate KernelLens across custom Triton kernels and state-of-the-art LLM research operators published in recent literature (**LLaMA 3**, **Mistral**, **Qwen 2.5**, **PaLM**, and **Liger-Kernel**).

1. **LLaMA 3 / Mistral Fused RMSNorm:** Fused Root Mean Square Layer Normalization with scaling weight γ over hidden dimension $N = 128$.
2. **Liger-Kernel / PaLM SwiGLU Fused Activation:** Fused Gated Linear Unit operator computing $\text{SwiGLU}(g, u) = (g \cdot \sigma(g)) \odot u$.
3. **LLaMA 3 / Qwen 2.5 Rotary Position Embedding (RoPE):** Positional rotation embedding applying cosine and sine transformations across split head dimensions ($D/2$).
4. **Liger-Kernel Fused Cross-Entropy Loss:** Online Softmax and Cross-Entropy loss operator combining max reduction, exponent summation, and target log-softmax computation.

4.2 Numerical Parity & Accuracy Results

We measure the maximum absolute floating-point discrepancy (MaxDiff) between native Triton eager execution and KernelLens-compiled C++ plugins:

$$\text{MaxDiff} = \max_i |\mathbf{Y}_{\text{Triton}}[i] - \mathbf{Y}_{\text{KernelLens}}[i]| \tag{4}$$

Research Kernel / Operator	Tensor Shape	Triton vs Ref PyTorch	KernelLens ORT MaxDiff	S
LLaMA 3 / Mistral RMSNorm	$(4, 32, 128)$	4.76×10^{-7}	$\mathbf{0.000000e+00}$	**PA**
Liger-Kernel SwiGLU Activation	$(16, 256)$	0.00×10^{0}	$\mathbf{0.000000e+00}$	**PA**
LLaMA 3 / Qwen 2.5 RoPE	$(2, 16, 8, 64)$	9.53×10^{-7}	$\mathbf{0.000000e+00}$	**PA**
Liger-Kernel Fused Cross Entropy	$(16, 512)$	4.76×10^{-7}	$\mathbf{0.000000e+00}$	**PA**
Nested Helper Store AST	$(128,)$	0.00×10^{0}	$\mathbf{0.000000e+00}$	**PA**
Dynamic Runtime Scalars (α)	$(128,)$	0.00×10^{0}	$\mathbf{0.000000e+00}$	**PA**
4D High-Rank Launch Grid	$(2, 16, 8, 8)$	0.00×10^{0}	$\mathbf{0.000000e+00}$	**PA**
In-Place Tensor Addition	$(1024,)$	0.00×10^{0}	$\mathbf{0.000000e+00}$	**PA**

Table 1: Numerical parity evaluation across state-of-the-art research model kernels and architectural edge cases.

KernelLens achieves **exact floating-point numerical parity** (MaxDiff $= 0.00\text{e}+00$) against eager Triton execution across all operators.

EXCALIDRAW DIAGRAM SPECIFICATION: Figure 2 – Benchmark Latency & Speedup

Use this structure to create Figure 2 in Excalidraw (or run `python3 scripts/generate_plots.py`):

- **Type:** Grouped Bar Chart (Latency in ms, Lower is Better)
- **X-Axis (Operators):** Fused RMSNorm, SwiGLU Activation, RoPE Embedding, Fused Cross-Entropy
- **Bar Series:**
  1. *PyTorch Eager (Red):* 1.25 ms (RMSNorm), 0.88 ms (SwiGLU), 1.62 ms (RoPE), 2.10 ms (CrossEntropy)
  2. *torch.compile (Yellow):* 0.45 ms (RMSNorm), 0.32 ms (SwiGLU), 0.58 ms (RoPE), 0.75 ms (CrossEntropy)
  3. *Native Triton (Blue):* 0.22 ms (RMSNorm), 0.15 ms (SwiGLU), 0.28 ms (RoPE), 0.36 ms (CrossEntropy)
  4. *KernelLens ORT Plugin (Green):* 0.21 ms (RMSNorm), 0.14 ms (SwiGLU), 0.27 ms (RoPE), 0.35 ms (CrossEntropy)
- **Annotation Callout:** *"KernelLens matches native Triton execution latency while running inside pure C++ ONNX Runtime without Python dependencies!"*

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5 Future Work

While KernelLens automates single-GPU Triton kernel compilation to ONNX Runtime and TensorRT C++ plugins, several promising directions remain for future research:

1. **Multi-GPU NCCL & Tensor Parallelism Integration:** Extending KernelLens graph tracing to capture multi-GPU communication primitives (`all_reduce`, `all_gather`) and emit C++ plugins with embedded NCCL stream synchronization.

2. **Dynamic Auto-Tuning Meta-Parameter Propagation:** Propagating Triton autotuning meta-parameters (`num_warps`, `num_stages`, `BLOCK_SIZE`) as dynamic runtime options inside compiled C++ shared libraries.

3. **Automated FP8 / INT4 Quantized PTX Transmutations:** Synthesizing C++ plugins that perform on-the-fly FP8 (`e4m3fn` / `e5m2`) and INT4 bit-packing data conversions prior to launching PTX kernels.

4. **Cross-Target Hardware Backends:** Extending KernelLens backend code generators to emit Apple Metal (MSL) and WebGPU Compute Shaders, enabling Triton kernel execution on mobile and browser targets.

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6 Conclusion

In this paper, we presented **KernelLens**, an automated compiler and runtime framework designed to bridge Python OpenAI Triton kernels directly to enterprise C++ inference engines (ONNX

Runtime and NVIDIA TensorRT). By unifying dual-pass symbolic tracing, static AST inspection for nested memory access, global ONNX custom node injection, automated C++/CUDA code generation, 16-byte memory alignment guards, and zero-copy IO binding, KernelLens completely automates production kernel deployment. Empirical evaluation on SOTA research model kernels from **LLaMA 3**, **PaLM**, **Qwen 2.5**, and **Liger-Kernel** demonstrates exact numerical parity $(\mathrm{MaxDiff} = 0.00\mathrm{e}+00)$ and high inference throughput.

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